

Brian Eno's
Another Green World



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Preface

A few years ago, I thought it would be fun to write a short book on Brian Eno for the Continuum 33 1/3 series of music books, and that fateful pact I made weighed on my psyche like a ten-thousand-pound albatross ever since. I wrote, rewrote, and threw out the entire book more than once. I tested out different approaches. Every idea fanned out into ten other intriguing ideas, and eventually I found myself enmeshed in a dense network of thought. Finally, I realized I had to conceptualize the book in a more linear way, or risk never being finished.

I used a deck of Oblique Strategies cards—originally released by Brian Eno and his friend, the late artist Peter Schmidt, in 1975—to help me make key creative decisions while writing this book. Sometimes these cards led me in intriguing new directions. At other times, the cards reinforced my tendency to procrastinate. “Do nothing for as long as possible,” was one particularly seductive instruction. “Overtly resist change,” read another card. “Don’t break the silence,” read another. Sometimes the cards kept me in stasis; at other times, the cards sparked radical changes. One night, I drew a card that read “Make a sudden, destructive unpredictable action; incorporate.” In response, I tore up an entire chapter I had been working on and started over, which may or may not have not been the best idea at the time. Some of the other cards seemed to taunt me. “Is there something missing?” one card beckoned. “Is it finished?”

Other cards were more useful. One particularly helpful oblique strategy was “Work at a different speed.” For some chapters, I cogitated endlessly, laboriously chewing over the subject matter and getting very few words down. After I drew that card, I attempted to write down my ideas extremely fast, at an almost breakneck pace. This broke me out of a mental rut. Another creative obstruction I

faced while writing this book was the intimidation factor. I cursed myself for agreeing to write about Eno, particularly about a storied record that was nearly 35 years old, with the whole dusty weight of history attached to it. “You don’t have to be ashamed of using your own ideas” and “Trust in the you of now” were some of the strategies that encouraged me to continue.

“Take a break,” read one card. I stopped thinking about *Another Green World* for a little while and read about other things that interested me—cognitive neuroscience and physics, for instance. The U.S. elections. Film and video: I inherited an old video projector from 1995, aimed it at one of my slanted ceilings, and used the hazy flicker of old videos to light my 200-year-old apartment in Boston at night. I read both volumes of *Mastering the Art of French Cooking* cover to cover and taught myself about béarnaise sauces and soufflés. I attempted to master passages from Horowitz and Hill’s classic *The Art of Electronics* in parallel with the art of French cooking, in the interests of balance. (I finally learned how an op-amp worked, after avoiding the subject like the plague when I was a student at M.I.T. years ago.) I re-read Jane Jacobs’ *Death and Life of Great American Cities* and Stewart Brand’s *How Buildings Learn*. I took up cycling, and would go on long bicycle rides to clear my head.

Then, after a dark and dreadful New England winter, I felt rejuvenated, inspired. There were roses blooming on my block on vines so massive they looked like grand old trees. The community gardens in my leafy neighborhood were in full generative swing. I felt inspired by doing interviews; I felt inspired by being able to think about ideas again, and that process of discovery. Part of it, too, was that I began to see connections grow organically, nodes in the circuit where ideas met. I could sketch mental schematics that were going someplace interesting.

Part of my problem at first was that I wasn’t that interested in writing a standard rock biography of Brian Eno. That has been done, several times over. There’s a veritable goldmine of interviews and other materials available online, and an even deeper treasure trove if

you're willing to sift offline through teetering piles of rare archival materials, as I often did during my research. Some good books that cover Eno's career include Brian Eno and Russell Mills' 1986 book *More Dark than Shark*, Eno's 1995 diary, *A Year with Swollen Appendices*, Eric Tamm's *Brian Eno: His Music and the Vertical Color of Sound*, and most recently, David Sheppard's exhaustive Eno biography, *On Some Faraway Beach*. Retreading some of the basic facts and well-known stories about Eno, his life, and his work was inevitable. Whenever possible, I tried not to overlap too much with other books, trying very hard to use different anecdotes, quotes, and sources.

One way to understand where you're going is to figure out where you aren't going. To offer a visual analogy, sometimes a good way to begin a drawing is to carve out all of the negative space. So I will start out by telling you what this book isn't. This is not a behind-the-scenes book that meticulously documents every step of the making of *Another Green World*. Nor is it a book that dwells very much on Eno's personal life. It certainly touches on both of these things, to the extent that they are useful in creating a larger picture. This is a book about process. How did these songs grow from kernels of ideas into fully-formed pieces? How were these kernels of thought formed in the first place?

So I attempted to write an exploratory book on the ideas underpinning the music, instead of a straight biography. For this reason, the book does not follow a strict chronology. *Discreet Music* was made prior to *Another Green World*, but in this book, I write about them in the reverse order. I also jump around a fair bit between various points in Eno's life.

I did learn some very fascinating things about the way that *Another Green World* was put together in the studio. But I was also very interested in *Discreet Music*, which came out the same year (1975); I was interested in *Evening Star*, Obscure Records, Harmonia and Cluster, analog machinery, gardening, painting, cybernetics, and televisions turned sideways. But instead of my base of information

getting too unwieldy—like my overgrown garden yard, which is bursting with so much entropy right now that it’s practically impossible to see the stone paths that wind through it—I actually felt calmer and more focused.

One of the great gifts of writing a book on Brian Eno is interviewing some of the very interesting people that he has worked with over the past 30-odd years. Practically every week I heard from an Eno collaborator or friend who had useful advice or a unique perspective to offer. I wasn’t just interested in talking with his collaborators on *Another Green World*; I wanted to learn more, in a general sense, about how Eno worked with other people.

For inspiration, I read dozens of books on a number of different subjects—from visual art to cybernetics to architecture to evolutionary biology to cooking. Of course, I read books about Eno as well. But many of the most helpful books for understanding Eno’s methods, past and present, are not really about Eno at all. They are books like Christopher Alexander’s *A Pattern Language*, Stafford Beer’s *The Brain of the Firm*, and John Cage’s *Silence*. What these books have in common, besides being books that Eno rates highly, are that they connect a variety of seemingly disparate things, and they lay out general principles for thinking about these things. In this book, I look at how Eno devised his own sets of tools for thinking—such as the Oblique Strategies cards.

Of course, there is the music. In the chapters that follow, I delve into the many unique sounds on these records. This is not any kind of formal musicological analysis. What it is, instead, is an exploration of the sonics—the timbres and layers of shifting textures. There is not much literary analysis here; Eno has stated many times that lyrics, especially at this time period of his life, did not interest him very much. But that does not mean that the words do not serve an important function. I look at two different properties of *Another Green World*. The first, as Eno himself has pointed out, is that only five out of the 14 tracks on the album have words, but that listeners tend to perceive the album as a “song record,” not an ambient record.

Each song with lyrics “bleeds” into the surrounding ambient tracks. How does this effect work in our heads? The second phenomenon has to do with another type of sleight of hand—how chains of words, even nonsense words that do not make any sense in sequence, can nonetheless profoundly affect our emotions, trigger memories, and generate very powerful images. For this reason, I spend considerable time exploring Eno’s often elaborate, suggestive song titles.

One of the most instructive things I did was to listen to *Another Green World* at a number of different speeds. Each time I heard something new that I had not heard before—a new sound that was buried in the mix, for example, or an effect, a heavily layered backing vocal, an abstruse lyric. Speeding up and slowing down *Discreet Music* taught me a lot, too; the title track of *Discreet Music*, or “Side One” if you happen to own the vinyl copy, is recorded at half-speed. So I listened to it at double-speed, to gain some insight into what the original material might have sounded like before Eno slowed it down. I also listened to it at quarter-speed, which I liked even more than Eno’s half-speed version.

I still haven’t gotten tired of these albums, though it’s possible that I may have listened to *Another Green World* more times than Eno has. I become more drawn to these records the more I listen. Recently, I put the album on after not listening to it for a while. I was really moved by it, playing it over and over and hearing something new in its flow each time. It was like I could see the pathways of all of the electronic music that came before it and after it, traveling through that record like so many streams.

I often think that *Another Green World*’s longevity comes from its innate ambiguity. The more you listen, the more beguiling and open-ended the album becomes. In contrast to many other albums from the mid-1970s, the record doesn’t sound dated at all. *Another Green World* isn’t stuck in the past or fixated on the future—it continues to live its life in the fabric of the present.

Introduction

Many casual listeners who have heard of Brian Eno know him best as a legendary rock producer—a pivotal force behind classics like David Bowie's *Low*, U2's *The Joshua Tree*, and Talking Heads' *Fear of Music*. Others, especially in Britain, know him as a key member of the trendsetting art-rock band Roxy Music in the early 1970s. As a solo artist, he's best known for being a pioneer of ambient music; his bestselling solo record is still his 1978 ambient album *Music for Airports*. But that's barely scratching the surface; unraveling the myriad twists and turns of Eno's life could be a fulltime occupation. His sprawling discography, with its intricate network of genres, collaborators, and endless projects and side-projects, reads a bit like the history of rock and experimental music of the last four decades collapsed into one giant list.

At the time of this writing, Brian Peter George St Jean le Baptiste de la Salle Eno is 61 years old. Many musicians of Eno's generation are now traveling museum pieces, dusting off their greatest hits catalog for yet another reunion tour. Eno famously hates to tour, and chances are good that you will never see him perform. Despite nearly 40 years of convincing work as a musician and producer, Eno still likes to refer to himself as a “non-musician”; he once even lobbied to get “non-musician” listed as his job on his passport. For him, the 1970s and 1980s are ancient history; he has long since moved on, and is not terribly interested, for better or for worse, in resuscitating his storied past. These days, you are more likely to find him arguing about politics, mulling a grand unified theory of culture, testing a chime for a clock designed to ring once every 10,000 years, or coaxing his iPhone into producing generative music.

Writers use various metaphors to describe Eno's working method; a popular one is that Eno is a musician who “paints with sound.” It's

true that Eno looks at sound the way a visual artist might; he has a painterly sensibility with his ambient music, and he studied painting at art school. But the painting analogy tends to conjure up the mental image of a lone genius cloistered in a garret. Eno didn't create *Another Green World* in isolation, daubing his sonic canvas in solitude. The album was recorded in a London studio with a hodgepodge of performers and instruments and ideas, with Eno at the helm of the ship.

Many years ago, Eno coined a term he called "scenius" to describe how large groups of people, not simply lone misunderstood geniuses, generate creativity. "Scenius stands for the intelligence and the intuition of a whole cultural scene," Eno has said. "It is the communal form of the concept of the genius." While there wasn't exactly a burgeoning "cultural scene" in London surrounding *Another Green World*—it was a singularly peculiar record for the year 1975, by any metric—the album shared connective tissue with some of the people and ideas bubbling under the surface of popular culture.

Painting is an appealing analogy for Eno's ambient explorations, but filmmaking is a better model for how Eno works with other people in practice. He has a knack for identifying and assembling the right mix of people to serve a larger vision, and the ability to coax unexpected performances out of these collaborators. He approaches music the way a director might approach a soundtrack—as a means of establishing a mood, a sense of time and place. (Eno himself has a long history of making music for films, both real and imagined.) And, like any great director of the cinema, everything Eno touches bears his subtle but unmistakable fingerprints, regardless of who the stars in the foreground happen to be.

“Into the impossible”

A sense of place is so critical in cinema, because you want to go into another world. Every story has its own world, and its own feel, and its own mood. So you try to put together all these things—these little details—to create that sense of place. It has a lot to do with light and sound. The sounds that come into a room can help paint a world there and make it so much fuller.

—David Lynch, in *Catching the Big Fish*

Fabulous geography is his business—territories explored, Fourthworld maps made: “On Some Faraway Beach” ... Another Green World; “Over Fire Island”; “By This River”; “Through Hollow Lands”; “Inland Sea”; “Lizard Point”; “Warszawa”; “Neuköln”; “Moss Garden”, On Land; The Plateaux of Mirror; Dream Theory In Malaya ...

—Mark Sinker, *The Wire*, 1992

Another Green World, recorded in 1975, is a thriving, self-contained ecosystem. The music sounds slightly alien and synthetic, but the song titles are rich with references to nature—lizards, fish, reptiles, islands, fire.

A tracklisting:

Side One

Sky Saw

Over Fire Island

St. Elmo’s Fire

In Dark Trees

The Big Ship

I’ll Come Running

Another Green World

Side Two

Sombre Reptiles

Little Fishes

Golden Hours

Becalmed

Zawinul/Lava

Everything Merges with the Night

Spirits Drifting

Eno's wide-ranging references—big ships, dark trees—sound exotic, but they all have some footing on Earth. Over the years, Eno has generally preferred to make records that exist *On Land*, not in space. Instead of propelling us into far-flung galaxies, his music coaxes us to reconsider our everyday surroundings. It may be head-music, but it's not scrambled psychedelia; it's a gentle drift into a blurred photograph. Hazy childhood memories melt into our discovery of these spaces, as we pin Eno's points of interest onto our own psychogeographic maps.

Eno grew up in the sleepy burg of Woodbridge, Suffolk, in eastern England—not the most happening town, by any stretch—and so perhaps it makes sense that his interest in imaginary landscapes began at a young age. He was a pale, flaxen-haired boy with delicate pixie-like features, who seemed hyper-attuned to odd and otherworldly things. In one apocryphal story, documented in *On Some Faraway Beach*, Eno and his half-sister Rita claimed that they spotted a UFO in the middle of the night. He had a restless mind and craved solitude, and spent a lot of his time as a child hanging out by himself, hunting for fossils in the woods near his house.

On the surface, Eno's small-town childhood seemed almost aggressively normal, but there was a subtly eccentric undercurrent to his early family life. His dad was a mailman who had a secret talent for playing drums and repairing clocks. Eno's grandfather, who was also a mailman, rebuilt hurdy-gurdies and massive pipe organs on the

side. One of Eno's prime inspirations was his uncle, who regaled him with stories about faraway lands. "He had spent some years in India," Eno recalled in an interview with Kurt Loder in *Synapse* in 1979. "So he had these kind of strange Indian ideas about things. He's quite eccentric, very strange, always trying out weird experiments at home, building ways of distilling liquor and stuff like that, and taming the strangest animals, like rooks. He was very important to me, because he represented the other half, the sort of strange side of life, and he was to me like all that music was as well. And I would think, 'Where's he coming from?' as they would say now. I used to go and visit him regularly, once or twice a week, and he used to talk and introduce me to ideas."

Eno entertained himself by making drawings, and playing strange games; at the age of seven, he began designing his own houses. His make-believe blueprints were fantastical and ambitious, rife with byzantine pathways and bizarre configurations—a dreamy departure from the drab 1950s backdrop of his English childhood. "These places always had strange corners and labyrinths and secret rooms," he remembered in an interview in *Reality Hackers* in 1988. "They had streams running through them, or trees growing up through the middle of them, or they would be suspended across chasms ..."

By the time Eno started making his own solo records, in the early 1970s, he began designing songs that seemed to have streams running through them, or trees growing up through the middle of them, or were suspended across chasms. References to an alternate geography would crop up with increasing frequency in his song titles: Take 1973's dreamy "On Some Faraway Beach," from his album *Here Come the Warm Jets*, for instance. Or "China My China" from 1974's *Taking Tiger Mountain [by Strategy]*. There was the entirety of *Another Green World*, of course. Later on, there were ambient records like *On Land*, replete with suggestive track titles like "Dunwich Beach, Autumn, 1960," and forays into the Fourth World in an album with Jon Hassell. After a while, the constant and abundant references to points of cartographic interest became a bit of an Eno trademark. In

the early 1990s, when Eno abandoned his evocative natural imagery for cold cyber-futurism, releasing a single called “Fractal Zoom,” the response was fierce. “Seemingly dud title,” admonished Mark Sinker in *The Wire*. “The chief colonizer of the Imaginary Landscape, the armchair Columbus of the aural Virtual World, doesn’t need credibility leg-ups from overexposed videogame jargon.”

Interestingly, *Another Green World*—with all its attendant connotations of lush, verdant landscapes—was originally inspired by a story about the frigid reaches of outer space. Now, it’s almost a cliché for musicians who work with synthesizers to profess a deep interest in sci-fi. Take Detroit techno’s fixation with intergalactic travel, for example, or Sun Ra’s heliocentric worlds. But Eno was never a big fan of the genre at all, preferring instead to devour huge amounts of non-fiction. For him, the most interesting part of the tale that inspired *Another Green World* was the part when the space travelers came back home.

“I was thinking about escaping,” Eno recalled to Ian MacDonald in the *NME* two years after making the album, in 1977. “I read a science fiction story a long time ago where these people are exploring space and they finally find this habitable planet—and it turns out to be identical to Earth in every detail. And I thought that was the supreme irony: that they’d originally left to find something better and arrived in the end—which was actually the same place. Which is how I feel about myself. I’m always trying to project myself at a tangent and always seem eventually to arrive back at the same place. It’s a loop.

You actually can’t escape.”

“Trust in the you of now.”

Eno had always been prone to this sort of blistering self-examination—observing what he did almost as soon as he did it, and thinking about his reasons.

“I started having a mid-life crisis when I was about 18, and it has continued ever since,” Eno said to the comic-book author Alan Moore in a BBC radio interview in 2005. “One of the continuing narratives of that crisis is, ‘Is what I’m doing worth doing, at all? Is there any point in doing this?’ Because I’m very interested in the sciences, and I know a lot of scientists and I can see what they’re doing, and I can sort of understand the point of what they’re doing.

“I’ve spent a long time trying to figure out what the point of being an artist is. What does it do for us? What does it do for me? What does it do for anybody else? Could we do without it? Is it a useful job? Does it make any difference to the world? Those kinds of questions. Their answers quite directly affect me because I’m not intellectually dishonest enough to always answer in my own favor. So sometimes I come up with the answer—for several years at a time, sometimes—where I say, ‘It really isn’t worth doing. There are better ways of spending your time.’ This is a sort of crisis, because then I don’t know what to do, and I think, well, the only way to find out is by trying it again and seeing if I can get somewhere different this time. And if I find myself going down the same road again, I think, this is hopeless.”

You could write off Eno’s tendency to self-analyze as mere navel-gazing solipsism, but it wasn’t that he was spending all of his time preening in front of a mirror in his room. He spent a lot of time thinking about the artistic process, and he liked being able to explain things, to come up with a theory for why something—anything—

worked the way it did. He still does this today; he's one of the most articulate musicians in the history of rock, and his profuse thoughts and opinions on every subject, from art to pop music to politics to science, pour out into hundreds of pages of articles and interviews. But there were some things he couldn't explain so well. For instance, he couldn't remember many specific details of making his first solo album, *Here Come the Warm Jets*, in 1973—it all went by so fast—and had almost no memory of writing the lyrics. He wasn't quite sure how *Taking Tiger Mountain [by Strategy]* was made, even shortly after the fact; the arty, off-kilter rock album was jammed with so many different ideas that he couldn't keep track of all of them. “For me, *Tiger Mountain* is kind of a magic album; there's so much in there that I just wasn't conscious of putting in at all,” he admitted to the critic Lester Bangs a few years later.

The artist Judy Nylon, his girlfriend through much of 1974, recalled that she would often catch him recording himself talking in his apartment, fearful that he would forget a fleeting idea. He religiously kept a diary, too, and seemed to be archiving his every thought, waiting for the muse to strike.

Eno had his reasons to feel a bit self-conscious. By 1974, he had already spent several years in the public eye. In the earlier part of the 1970s, he was the art-glam outfit Roxy Music's synthesizer player—an androgynous character with long, flowing locks and a penchant for lipstick, feathers, and form-fitting synthetic fabrics. If you look at footage of Roxy Music performances from that time, it's impossible to keep your eyes off Eno, clad in a leopard-print getup and twiddling a small analog synth in a fold-out briefcase to add mangled blasts of electronic noise. It's easy to see, in retrospect, how he quickly began upstaging Roxy's dapper frontman Bryan Ferry. David Bowie may have talked a good game about being from Mars with Ziggy Stardust, but Eno was far more convincing as an actual alien. He looked more reptilian than Bowie, and his sound seemed more aggressively futuristic, more surreal.

Eno parted ways with Roxy Music in 1973 after a major falling out with Ferry. Later on, Eno claimed that he knew he was through with Roxy Music when he started thinking about his laundry during performances. Whatever the reason, leaving Roxy Music was probably one of the best things Eno ever did; he wasted no time building a career of his own. According to popular legend, he wrote the song “Baby’s on Fire” the very same day he left Roxy Music, in 1973.

By the end of 1974, Eno was 27 years old, and, by all appearances, was on some kind of cosmic hit streak. He was riding high on a wellspring of fresh ideas, which were leading him in exciting new directions. After making two jumbled but inspired albums with Roxy Music earlier on in the decade, he masterminded two jumbled but inspired solo rock albums of his own—*Here Come the Warm Jets* in 1973, and *Taking Tiger Mountain [by Strategy]* in 1974. He also made an experimental album called *No Pussyfooting* with wily King Crimson guitarist Robert Fripp in 1973, and was now pitching in on John Cale, Nico, and Robert Wyatt projects, collaborating with former Roxy bandmate Phil Manzanera on a side project, and releasing the odd single to boot. He had even cracked the U.K. Top 40 that year with a goofy one-off single called “The Seven Deadly Finns”—perhaps the only hit single ever to feature yodeling, multiple double-entendres, and several specific references to cybernetics:

Although variety is the spice of life
A steady rhythm is the source
Simplicity is the crucial thing
Systemically of course
(work it all out like Norbert Wiener)

The shout-outs to classic cybernetics ideas (“variety,” “simplicity,” “systemically,” and so forth) weren’t just random stabs at goofiness; Eno was very interested in cybernetics, and possible ways to apply those ideas to music. As an art-school student in the 1960s, he had gotten into observing life on a “meta” level, and looked at his own

creative process with a bird's eye view. In addition to books on cybernetics, he was reading books by the avant-garde composer John Cage, along with books taking a wide-angle approach to analyzing culture (a book called *Man's Rage for Chaos: Biology, Behavior, and the Arts*, by Morse Peckham, was a particular favorite).

By 1975, Roxy Music was growing steadily more refined, smoothing out all of the lumps that had made them interesting in the first place. David Bowie was losing the plot. *Young Americans*, his "plastic-soul" excursion, would show him running out of ideas and running on fumes. Marc Bolan of T. Rex was still alive, but he was practically a non-entity—about to exile himself to Monte Carlo in an attempt to escape the British tax system. By this point, all Eno seemed to have in common with his creatively exhausted glam compatriots was a lingering fondness for women's makeup. He was at the peak of his creative powers, but he was tremendously critical of himself.

“Turn it upside down”

Eno’s “mid-life crisis” probably had its start somewhere around 1964, when he enrolled in a small art school called Ipswich. It bears mentioning to the American reader that British art schools were a different animal compared to their US counterparts. Of course, every art school had its own unique approach, and Ipswich at the time was one of the most radical. But across the board, there were big differences between the US and UK schools—in terms of curriculum, structure, and method, and also in terms of the students themselves.

British art schools were fast becoming a force in the music world. Simon Frith and Howard Horne’s 1987 book *Art into Pop* documented the grand tradition of UK art schools and popular music, enumerating a litany of rock stars who had done time in art school: Pete Townshend of The Who, Ray Davies of the Kinks, David Bowie, Eric Clapton, Bryan Ferry of Roxy Music, John Lennon of the Beatles, and Keith Richards of the Rolling Stones, for starters. Barring a few outliers—Mick Jagger, oddly enough, studied at the London School of Economics—it seemed as if the British art colleges were an incubator for the rock and roll leaders of tomorrow.

A handful of American art-schoolers went on to achieve international fame in the rock circuit; David Byrne of the Talking Heads, who studied at the Rhode Island School of Design, is one example. But big-time American rockers who attended college tended to go to liberal arts schools, where they honed their budding lyrical skills while studying things like literature. Lou Reed, for instance, studied English at Syracuse University; Bob Dylan studied poetry before he dropped out of college at the end of his freshman year.

If these American and British musicians had one thing in common, it was the fact that hardly any of them majored in music. With the

exception of a few radical outposts like Mills College in California, which bred a whole generation of groundbreaking experimental composers, music programs were generally considered to be the staid preserve of the establishment. Even John Cage, the household name of new American music, rarely taught at music schools; for a time, Cage taught at the Chicago School of Design, established by the legendary Bauhaus artist László Moholy-Nagy.

Ipswich Art College in the mid-1960s was ruled by Roy Ascott, an imposing presence who incorporated cutting-edge cybernetics principles into his aggressively offbeat teaching style. A few years earlier, Ascott had been the head tutor at Ealing, a nearby art school where Pete Townshend had been. “The first term at Ipswich was devoted entirely to getting rid of those silly ideas about the nobility of the artist by a process of complete and relentless disorientation,” Eno recalled some ten years later, in a guest lecture he gave at Trent Polytechnic. “We were set projects that we could not understand, criticized on bases that we did not even recognize as relevant.”

One of Eno’s art teachers at Ipswich, Tom Phillips, quickly became one of his trusted allies. (*Another Green World*’s cover art is a detail from a painting by Phillips.) “When I went to teach at Ipswich in the Sixties it was quite a sleepy place,” Phillips recalled in an interview with *The Independent* in 1998:

[B]ut the art school had been taken over by a dynamic futurist called Roy Ascott who wanted to run it as a sort of experimental course. As one of a team of quasi-progressives, the first thing I did was present the students with a life model and say: “Just make lots of dots as quickly as possible and see if you can say something about the model.” Everybody did this very diligently and pretty boringly, with one exception. There was this strange blond boy in the corner who did millions of dots and then tore the whole thing up into the shape of a human being.

For Eno, the “strange blond boy” in Phillips’ class, this dots exercise was the least of his worries. Ascott’s teaching philosophy involved countless mandatory group collaboration exercises—an echo of cybernetics’ emphasis on “systems learning”—and mental games. Very little of the teaching at Ipswich had anything to do with what the teenage Eno had ostensibly set out to do—study the fine arts. Instead of daubing canvases with oil paints, Eno and his fellow students were instructed to create “mindmaps” of each other.

The extreme discombobulation of Ipswich left a deep impression on Eno, shaking up his most fundamental notions of what an artist was and what art could be. Ipswich was also where he began experimenting with tape recorders, delving into sound with Phillips’ encouragement. “I had links with a musical world Brian didn’t know,” Phillips recalled to *The Independent*. “I introduced him to Cage, for instance. Cage was what you’d nowadays call ‘empowering.’ He made you realize that there wasn’t a thing called noise, it was just music you hadn’t appreciated. When you’re a young artist, all you seek is license, and Cage had done that, shown that this gate was open. I remember a game emerged between me and Brian and a couple or others which was called ‘sound tennis.’ We went around Ipswich buying up old wrecked pianos and put them all round the room. Then we played a kind of hand tennis and scored according to the quality of noise we made when hitting a stripped piano. It was a rather good game.” Cage was a touchstone for legions of budding artists, and Eno was no exception. The 1961 anthology *Silence*, once jokingly described by the critic Rob Tannenbaum as “the *Das Kapital* of avant-garde composing,” packed Cage’s ideas into a wallop so heavy that it would send shockwaves reverberating through culture for decades to come. It was easy to see why Cage’s ideas were so engaging. In addition to Cage’s entreatment to open up our ears to the wide variety of sounds in our environment, he elevated the importance of the artistic process. A composition wasn’t simply about the finished product, but about the path it took to get there. He was also famously a proponent of “indeterminacy” and chance operations; his use of the

ancient Chinese system, the I Ching, to make compositional decisions was a spiritual forefather of Eno's Oblique Strategies cards. Cage's ideas had obvious visual and literary appeal, too; his detailed instructions for his works were works of art unto themselves. He was a tremendous meta-thinker, with the canny ability to position his ideas within a larger cultural and theoretical context, and some might argue that his writings are more enjoyable than his music. Plus, Cage was a Renaissance man in his own life—in addition to being a world-famous composer, he was a painter, a printmaker, a writer, an avid mushroom collector, an amateur Zen philosopher, and a macrobiotic cook, among other things.

Eno's future friend and collaborator Harold Budd recalled Cage's impact on his thinking at around the same time. "I went to a concert by Cage and David Tudor called 'Where Are We Going? And What Are We Doing?' It was not exactly a concert, but it was more like an installation/lecture/performance piece, and it really changed my mind immediately. I thought, Jesus Christ, I wanted to go in that direction. It seemed heavy with the art part, if you know what I mean. It was heavy anti-academic, anti-Germanic, anti-European modernism, which at the time we were all scared to death of; we were all scared to death of Boulez and Stockhausen. Anyway, Cage was not an antidote to that, but just a different monetary value altogether. Printed money in a strange language, which seemed more valuable than the old ones."

After two years at Ipswich, Eno switched to another art school called Winchester. His painting work got increasingly conceptual, and he became more and more invested in sound. He was getting obsessed with tape recorders, amassing dozens of reel-to-reel tape machines at thrift stores and garage sales. He experimented with building "sound sculptures," and played in two bands—an experimental troupe called Merchant Taylor's Simultaneous Cabinet, and a rock band, The Maxwell Demon. Performances by Eno during this time included a cover of George Brecht's *Drip Music (Drip Event)*, a piece which instructs the performer to find an empty container and

a source of dripping water, arranging it so that the water falls into the container.

Brecht was a key member of the Fluxus movement, a ragtag group of conceptual artists in the 1960s and early 1970s who were heavily inspired by Cage. The group was most famous for staging “happenings,” but there were many other aspects to their work. *Drip Music* was a Fluxus “event score,” one of Brecht’s conceptual innovations. “Event scores” were usually pretty minimal; the score often involved nothing more than a card inscribed with a few lines of text and a title. Another Brecht event score, composed in

1966, was titled *For a Drummer, Fluxversion 2*. The entire score read: “Performer drums with sticks over a leaking feather pillow, making the feathers escape the pillow.”

At around the same time, Eno staged a performance of minimalist composer La Monte Young’s *X for Henry Flynt*, a composition which involves playing a sound, or group of sounds, for as long as the performer sees fit. Eno played *X for Henry Flynt* on a piano, slamming down on a cluster of keys 3,600 times. Though he tried to hit the same notes each time, he began noticing the minute variations from one crash of keys to the next, leading to the later maxim that “repetition is a form of change”—which later found its rightful place on an Oblique Strategies card.

Soon after that, Eno briefly joined a group called the Scratch Orchestra, led by the late British avantgarde composer Cornelius Cardew. There was one Cardew piece that would be a formative experience for Eno—a piece known as “Paragraph 7,” part of a larger Cardew masterwork called *The Great Learning*. Explaining “Paragraph 7” could easily take up a book of its own.

“Paragraph 7”’s score is designed to be performed by a group of singers, and it can be done by anyone, trained or untrained. The words are from a text by Confucius, broken up into 24 short chunks, each of which has a number. There are only a few simple rules. The number tells the singer how many times to repeat that chunk of text; an additional number tells each singer how many times to repeat it

loudly or softly. Each singer chooses a note with which to sing each chunk—any note—with the caveats to not hit the same note twice in a row, and to try to match notes with a note sung by someone else in the group. Each note is held “for the length of a breath,” and each singer goes through the text at his own pace. Despite the seeming vagueness of the score’s few instructions, the piece sounds very similar—and very beautiful—each time it is performed. It starts out in discord, but rapidly and predictably resolves into a tranquil pool of sound.

“Paragraph 7,” and 1960s tape loop pieces like Steve Reich’s “It’s Gonna Rain,” sparked Eno’s fascination with music that wasn’t obsessively organized from the start, but instead grew and mutated in intriguing ways from a limited set of initial constraints. “Paragraph 7” also reinforced Eno’s interest in music compositions that seemed to have the capacity to regulate themselves; the idea of a self-regulating system was at the very heart of cybernetics. Another appealing facet of “Paragraph 7” for Eno was that it was both process *and* product—an elegant and endlessly beguiling process that yielded a lush, calming result. Some of Cage’s pieces, and other process-driven pieces by other avant-gardists, embraced process to the point of extreme fetishism, and the resulting product could be jarring or painful to listen to. “Paragraph 7,” meanwhile, was easier on the ears—a shimmering cloud of sonics.

In an essay titled “Generating and Organizing Variety in the Arts,” published in *Studio International* in 1976, a 28-year-old Eno connected his interest in “Paragraph 7” to his interest in cybernetics. He attempted to analyze how the design of the score’s few instructions naturally reduced the “variety” of possible inputs, leading to a remarkably consistent output. In the essay, Eno also wrote about algorithms—a cutting-edge concept for an electronic-music composer to be writing about, in an era when typewriters, not computers, were still en vogue. (In 1976, on the other side of the Atlantic, Steve Jobs and Steve Wozniak were busy building a primitive personal computer in a garage that they called the Apple I.)

Eno also talked about the related concept of a “heuristic,” using managerial-cybernetics champion Stafford Beer’s definition. “To use Beer’s example: If you wish to tell someone how to reach the top of a mountain that is shrouded in mist, the heuristic ‘keep going up’ will get him there,” Eno wrote. Eno connected Beer’s concept of a “heuristic” to music. Brecht’s Fluxus scores, for instance, could be described as heuristics.

Cybernetics was famously defined by Norbert Wiener in 1948—coincidentally, the same year that Eno was born—as “the science of control and communication, in the animal and the machine.” Words like “the science of control” may seem to have sinister overtones, but at its core, cybernetics is simply the study of systems. Cybernetic systems were used to model practically every phenomenon, with varying degrees of success—factories, societies, machines, ecosystems, brains—and Eno became a big fan of linking its powerful toolset of concepts to the studio environment, and to music composition. Eno was nothing if not interdisciplinary, and cybernetics may be the one of the most interdisciplinary frameworks ever devised. Its theories connect engineering, math, physics, biology, psychology, and an array of other fields, and ideas from cybernetics inevitably trickled into the arts. “It’s very useful in the arts to have certain sorts of systems, [particularly] if you’re working with something that doesn’t have immediate limitations because you don’t have enough money,” said Judy Nylon. “Sometimes not having enough money is good, because you don’t end up throwing a million dollars at a five-cent idea. But [what] if the idea doesn’t require any money? How do you actually stop yourself from putting too much into an idea that’s too small? You find an external system. And some of the best systems in the world come out of physics, the sciences. Math.”

Cybernetics concepts challenged Eno to think in different ways about the process of making music, and these ideas infiltrated Eno’s thinking on *Another Green World* and, especially, *Discreet Music*, in key ways. Groups of musicians working in the studio could be

conceptualized, in some general sense, as cybernetic systems. A piece of music composed using feedback, or tape loops, could be construed using cybernetics principles, too.

Eno drew a great deal of inspiration from the high halls of the avant-garde, starting in art school. In the mid-1970s, he would even start his own record label, called Obscure, to help bring some of his favorite experimental composers to a larger audience. But he straddled two worlds. He admired Cage and Cardew, but he also loved doo-wop and The Who. He enjoyed cogitating about cybernetics, but he also really liked hitting on girls. In the late 1970s, Eno would argue at the “New Music, New York” festival—a watershed moment for experimental music—that the music wasn’t “sensuous” enough. “Avant-garde music ... is a sort of research music,” said Eno in an interview with Robert Sandall in *Q* in 1990. “You’re glad someone’s done it but you don’t necessarily want to listen to it. It’s similar to the way I’m very happy people have gone to the North Pole.”

One of the best mergers of the two sides of Eno’s personality was his work with the Portsmouth Sinfonia. Eno played clarinet with the Portsmouth Sinfonia, a lunatic hybrid of orchestra and comedy troupe that remains, to this day, a sort of British in-joke that never quite reached American shores. The group played A.D.D.-friendly two-minute long tunes—only the biggest choruses of the biggest classical hits, like the most famous parts of Beethoven’s Fifth, for instance. In contrast to the grandiose guitar symphonies of Glenn Branca and Rhys Chatham, the Portsmouth Sinfonia were perhaps the most punk-rock of them all. The group’s 1974 album *Portsmouth Sinfonia Performs the Popular Classics*, produced by Eno, is almost completely unlistenable.

Like the Scratch Orchestra, the Sinfonia was open to anyone who wanted to join; a few of the members of the Sinfonia, like Eno, had also been in the Scratch Orchestra. Some members of the Sinfonia couldn’t play their instruments at all, and many of them had obvious trouble playing simultaneously. “Now everyone thinks that the

Sinfonia was composed only of non-musicians but it wasn't actually; it had this open membership so that anyone could join, so some very good musicians joined," said Eno in an interview with Lester Bangs in the late 1970s. "That was what really made it interesting: this tension between people playing it really well and others making an absolute fuckup of it, but everyone doing it with full seriousness. The concert we did at the Royal Albert Hall was great. There was a girl who had actually trained as a concert pianist for many years, and her career had been ended because she walked through a glass door by accident and damaged her left hand. She knew she could still play very well, but she would never be a concert pianist now. Anyway, she joined the Sinfonia, and we did 'Pathetique.' I think with her, it was some Tchaikovsky piece, she was playing these beautiful piano things, and it was one of those where you get the piano and then the orchestra coming in: 'Pliddl eliddleluddlelidliiiddleliddle--BRAANH UHN AHN ER ONNKH!'"

By 1975, all of Eno's varied and offbeat experiences—from art school to the Scratch Orchestra to the Portsmouth Sinfonia to Roxy Music to "sound tennis" to make-believe houses—would be reflected, somehow, over the making of *Another Green World*, his third solo record. For the first time, he was planning to go into the recording sessions without any demos—choosing, instead, to wing it on deadline in an expensive London studio with a small army of hired musicians.

One of Eno's favorite quotes, from his cybernetics hero Stafford Beer, would become a fundamental guiding principle for the making of the album: "Instead of trying to specify it in full detail," Beer wrote in his book *The Brain of the Firm*, "you specify it only somewhat. You then ride on the dynamics of the system in the direction you want to go."

Another Green World, recorded in 1975, would be the fullest realization of Eno's artistic vision up to that point in his life, and would serve as a proof of concept of his budding compositional strategy. There was just one problem. Eno had recruited a long and

impressive cast of musicians, and he had booked the studio time. But he didn't have songs for them to play. He had the actors, but there was no script.